

Getting Started with AWS Academy & Skill Builder

A step-by-step guide for **ITNW 1009** students to access your AWS Academy Learner Lab, activate your complimentary Skill Builder subscription, and complete your first hands-on cloud environment lab.

ITNW 1009

AWS ACADEMY

SKILL BUILDER



What We'll Cover Today

This guide walks you through three major milestones. Follow each section in order — each step builds on the previous one.

01

Access AWS Academy

Enroll in your ITNW 1009 course on the AWS Academy Canvas portal using your student email and join code.

02

Activate AWS Skill Builder

Unlock your free 12-month premium subscription — including hands-on labs, role-based learning paths, and certification vouchers.

03

Complete Intro Lab

Start your sandbox environment, navigate the AWS Management Console, inspect IAM roles, and review your billing dashboard.

PART 1

Accessing the AWS Academy Course

To get started, you'll need two things: your **official college student email address** and the **email from AWS Academy**. Do *not* use a personal Gmail or Yahoo address – AWS Academy ties access to your institutional account.

⚠️ Never create a second AWS Academy account if your invitation expires. Email your instructor instead and request a fresh invite link.



Step-by-Step: Enrolling in AWS Academy

1

Check Your Email

Look for an invitation from **awsacademy.instructure.com**. Not there? Check your spam/junk folder, then ask your instructor to resend the invite.

2

Create or Sign In

Go to **awsacademy.instructure.com**. First-time users create an account with their student email. Returning users log in with existing credentials.

3

Confirm Enrollment

Verify that **ITNW 1009** appears on your Dashboard. Click into the course and find the **Modules** page — all AWS labs will be posted here.

PART 2

Your Free AWS Skill Builder Subscription

As an active AWS Academy learner, you qualify for a **complimentary 12-month subscription** to AWS Skill Builder — a premium learning platform normally unavailable for free. This is one of the most valuable perks of your enrollment, so activate it early and take full advantage throughout the semester.

600+

Premium Courses

Self-paced, interactive content across all AWS domains

4

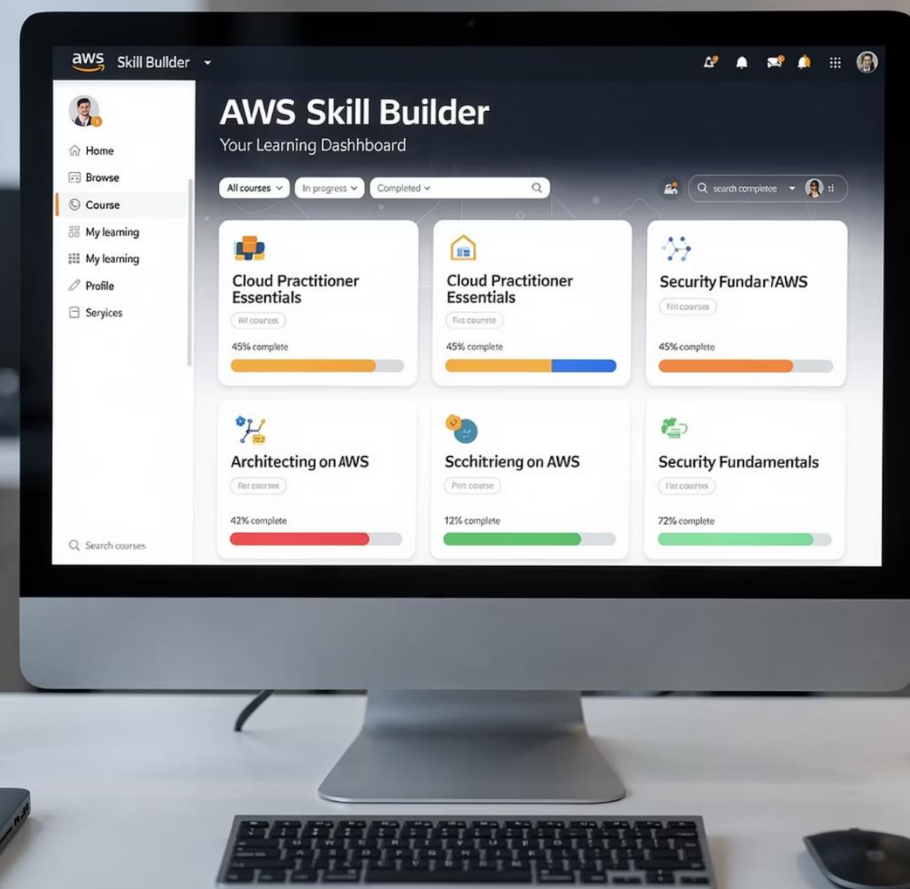
Free Cert Vouchers

Up to 4 discounted certification exam vouchers available

12

Months Free

Full subscription length from the date you activate



How to Activate Skill Builder

 You **cannot** activate this offer from the public Skill Builder website. You must go through your AWS Academy Canvas portal.

1

Log In

Access your AWS Academy Canvas dashboard through your institution's LMS.

2

Open a Course

Open any active AWS Academy course and click the **Modules** tab.

3

Find Resources

Scroll to the bottom and click **AWS T&C Resources**.

4

Activate & Complete

Click **Activate Your AWS Skill Builder Offer**, accept terms, complete the survey, and sign in to your Skill Builder profile.

What Skill Builder Unlocks for You



600+ Courses

Premium, interactive, self-paced courses covering every AWS service and domain — all free for 12 months.



Role-Based Learning Plans

Guided tracks for Cloud Practitioner, AI Practitioner, Developer, and Solutions Architect certifications.



Hands-On Labs

Practice real-world scenarios in live, sandboxed AWS environments — no credit card required.



Exam Prep

Domain review courses and official AWS practice exams to prepare for globally recognized certifications.



Activate your Skill Builder subscription as soon as possible — your 12 months begin on the day you redeem the offer, not the last day of the semester.

PART 3 – INTRO LAB

Lab: Navigating the AWS Cloud Environment

In this first hands-on lab, you will start your sandboxed AWS Academy student environment, tour the AWS Management Console, inspect pre-provisioned security roles, and review your billing dashboard — all within a safe, restricted student account.



Lab Objectives

By the end of this lab, you will be able to complete all four of the following tasks independently.

01 — Launch the Sandbox

Start your AWS Academy student lab sandbox environment safely and wait for it to fully initialize before proceeding.

02 — Navigate the Console

Use the global AWS Management Console search bar and navigation tools to locate and access core services.

03 — Inspect IAM & Security

Locate your deployment region, find the pre-provisioned **LabRole** security profile, and understand its purpose in your lab environment.

04 — Review Billing Dashboard

Access the billing dashboard to monitor spending indicators, free tier usage, and your \$100 sandbox credit allocation.

Critical Lab Environment Constraints

Read these rules carefully **before clicking anything** in the AWS Console. Violating them can cause immediate errors or lock you out of your lab environment.

Do NOT Create Custom Security Structures

Never create custom **IAM Users**, custom **IAM Groups**, custom **IAM Policies**, or custom **Root Billing** structures. Your student environment will throw an *Access Denied* error immediately.

Always Use LabRole

Whenever you launch compute resources, databases, or storage in future labs, you must always attach the pre-provisioned security role named **LabRole**. Never create a new role from scratch.

Automated Checkpoints Are Active

This lab uses an integrated check system inside your student manual. Click the **Check** buttons in your instruction panel to verify configuration tasks in real time.

Task 1: Starting Your Sandbox Lab Environment

Before you can access any AWS service, you need to spin up your personal, isolated student lab account. Follow each step precisely — do not skip ahead.

1 Open the Learner Lab Portal

Launch your browser and navigate to your official **AWS Academy Learner Lab** portal dashboard page via your institution's LMS.

2 Click "Start Lab" Once

Locate the floating command menu at the top of the course screen. Find **Start Lab** (with a small status circle icon) and click it *once only*. The indicator will turn **amber**, meaning the backend AWS provisioning engine is building your isolated environment.

3 Wait for Green — Then Click AWS

Wait patiently for the status circle to turn **solid green**. Once green, click the **AWS** link next to the green dot. A new browser tab will open, logging you directly into the live AWS Management Console.

 Never click "Start Lab" more than once. Repeated clicks can queue duplicate provisioning requests and delay your environment significantly.

Task 2: Navigating the AWS Management Console

The AWS Management Console is your primary interface for every cloud resource you will interact with. Learning to navigate it efficiently is a foundational skill for every cloud practitioner.

Using the Search Bar

The fastest way to find any service is the **Search bar** at the top center of the console (keyboard shortcut: **/**). Type a service name and select it from the filtered dropdown under **Services**.

Type **IAM** into the search bar now. Under Services, click **IAM (Identity and Access Management)** to load the IAM dashboard.

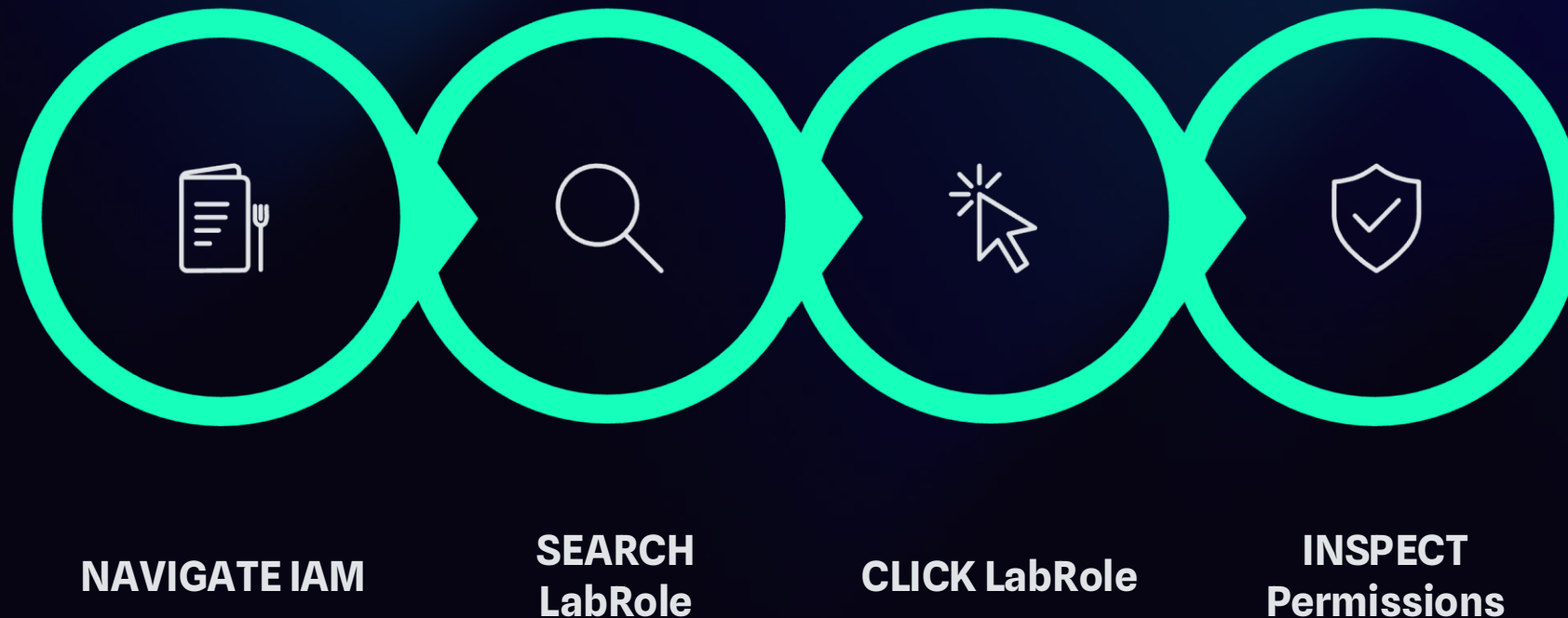
What to Notice on the IAM Dashboard

Once the IAM page loads, look for a status line that reads: **"IAM is a Global Service."** This is important – it means IAM configurations are not tied to a specific region. Any identity or access rule you create in IAM applies automatically across the *entire* global AWS infrastructure, not just in one data center location.

Take a moment to familiarize yourself with the left-side navigation panel – you will return to it in the next task.

Task 3: Verifying the LabRole Security Profile

The **LabRole** is the single most important configuration in your student environment. It is a pre-built AWS Identity and Access Management (IAM) role that grants you the cloud permissions you need to complete every lab — without requiring you to build complex security policies yourself. In this task, you will locate, inspect, and understand what LabRole does and why it matters.



Follow the detailed steps on the next cards to complete each part of this task successfully.

Task 3 — Step 1: Open the IAM Roles Panel

From the main IAM dashboard, you will navigate into the Roles section — the directory of all security profiles configured in your student account.

1

Stay on the IAM Dashboard

If you navigated away, use the top search bar (/) to search **IAM** again and click back into the IAM service page.

2

Locate the Left Navigation Panel

Look at the **left-hand vertical navigation column**. You will see a hierarchical list of IAM resource categories: Users, User Groups, Roles, Policies, and more.

3

Click on "Roles"

Click the menu item explicitly labeled **Roles**. The main content area will load a table listing all IAM roles currently available in your sandboxed student account.

4

Observe the Roles Table

Notice that several roles are already pre-provisioned for you by the AWS Academy system. You do not need to create any new roles — they are already here. Your job is to *find* and *inspect* the one named LabRole.

Task 3 — Step 2: Search for and Inspect LabRole

With the Roles table loaded, you will now filter the list, find LabRole, and examine what it contains. Understanding a security role's configuration is a core AWS administrator skill.

1 Use the Filter Search Box

Locate the **search filter text field** directly above the roles table. Type `LabRo1e` into the box and press **Enter**. The table will filter down to show only roles whose names match your search string.

2 Verify LabRole Appears

Confirm that a role named exactly **LabRole** appears as a row in the filtered table. If it does not appear, double-check your spelling — it is case-sensitive. If it is still missing, notify your instructor, as this may indicate your sandbox did not initialize correctly.

3 Click the LabRole Name Link

Click the blue hyperlinked text **LabRole** in the table to open its full detail and summary page. Do not click the checkbox — click the name link itself to open the role configuration view.

4 Inspect the Summary Page

On the LabRole summary page, examine the **Permissions policies** tab. You will see one or more broad AWS-managed policies attached to this role. Notice the **Trust relationships** tab as well — it defines which AWS services are allowed to *assume*(use) this role when performing actions on your behalf.

5 Note Who Manages LabRole

Observe that LabRole is **managed by AWS Academy**, not by you. This is intentional — the Academy configures it with exactly the permissions needed for your coursework, no more and no less. You are a *consumer* of this role, not its administrator.

Task 3 — Step 3: Understanding What LabRole Means for Future Labs

Inspecting LabRole is not just a checkbox exercise — it teaches you a fundamental AWS security concept: the principle of using **pre-defined roles** rather than creating ad hoc permissions. Here is what you need to understand going forward.



Why LabRole Exists

Rather than granting you unrestricted root-level access, AWS Academy uses LabRole to give you *just enough* permission to complete your labs safely — protecting both you and the shared infrastructure.



When to Attach It

Every time you launch an EC2 instance, create an RDS database, or configure an S3 bucket in future labs, you will be prompted to attach an IAM role. Always select **LabRole** from the dropdown — never skip this step or create a custom role.



What Happens If You Skip It

Launching resources without attaching LabRole — or attempting to create a new custom role — will result in an **Access Denied** error. Your environment will block the action, and you may need to delete and re-create the resource from scratch.



LabRole Is Region-Aware

Unlike IAM itself (which is global), the *resources* you attach LabRole to are region-specific. Always confirm your region selector before launching resources — mismatched regions will cause your resources to appear missing.

Task 4: Inspecting Regional Settings & the Billing Dashboard

Before wrapping up the lab, you will confirm your deployment region and review your sandbox budget — two habits every cloud professional develops early.

Checking Your Region

Look at the **top-right corner** of the dark navigation bar. You will see a geographic location name (e.g., **N. Virginia** or **Oregon**). Click it to open the regional dropdown and view all available AWS global data centers. Ensure your selector is set to your **course-assigned region** — typically `us-east-1` (N. Virginia) or `us-west-2` (Oregon). Switching regions accidentally is one of the most common reasons resources appear to "disappear."

Accessing the Billing Dashboard

Click your **account name** (top-right of the nav bar) to open a dropdown menu. Click **Billing Dashboard**.

On the Billing Dashboard, locate the **Summary** panel and the **AWS Free Tier** usage tracker. Your sandbox has a fixed **\$100 credit ceiling**. Monitor this regularly — if you run out of credits before the semester ends, you will lose access to your lab environment. Check back here after every major lab session.

 Never change your region mid-lab. Resources are region-specific — switching regions will make them appear missing, even though they still exist (and are still consuming credits).

Common Lab Troubleshooting Guide

Encountering an error? Match your symptom below and follow the remediation steps exactly.

Observed Error Symptom	Root Cause	Remediation Action
Access Denied banner appears when clicking a service or creating a resource	Attempting to create unauthorized configurations such as a custom IAM user, custom policy, or billing alert	Stop the action immediately. Navigate back to the main dashboard using the search bar and stick strictly to the pre-allocated lab tasks. Do not retry the blocked action.
AWS icon link dot is dark or unclickable — console won't open	The student backend sandbox has not finished spinning up yet — still in amber state	Return to the portal window, confirm the status indicator is still amber, wait 60 seconds, and refresh the page. Do not click Start Lab again.
Resource tables appear empty or missing inside a service dashboard	Region selector has accidentally switched to a different geographic zone	Click the region dropdown (top-right of the nav bar) and switch back to your designated primary region. Your resources will reappear.
LabRole does not appear in the IAM Roles filter results	Sandbox did not initialize correctly, or there is a typo in the search filter	Double-check spelling of LabRole (case-sensitive). If still missing, end the lab, wait 2 minutes, restart it, and try again. Contact your instructor if the issue persists.

You're Ready to Build in the Cloud!

You've now completed the three essential setup steps for ITNW 1009. From here, every weekly lab will follow the same pattern – start your sandbox, navigate the console, and complete guided tasks using your pre-provisioned LabRole.

AWS Academy Access

Enrolled and confirmed in ITNW 1009 with your student email and join code.

Skill Builder Activated

12-month premium subscription active – start exploring courses and earning certification vouchers.

Intro Lab Complete

Console navigated, LabRole verified, billing dashboard reviewed, and validation checkpoint submitted.

❏ Questions? Reach out to your instructor during office hours or post in the class LMS discussion board. Don't wait until the night before a lab deadline!

